believer in astrologers and gurus. During one meeting, he introduced me to a gent who looked a bit like one of the less pleasant creatures from Tolkein's *Lord of the Rings*. 'This man can predict your future,' he assured me. It was a bit surreal. I had gone to interview a powerful politician but was instead given a discourse in palmistry and planetary perambulations.

Perhaps the political stars were with Modi in 2014 and the netas could foresee the future. Smaller parties from the north-east also joined the NDA. But the big prize came from Andhra Pradesh when Chandrababu Naidu, another former chief minister, formally shook hands with the BJP. This alliance had been in the making for months. Naidu, we were told, was desperate because he was running out of cash in a state where money plays a major role at election time. His great rival, Jagan Reddy, by contrast, was flush with funds. Naidu needed Modi for his political survival.

The journey of Naidu reflects how no one can be written off in Indian politics easily. Between 1999 and 2004, Naidu, the bearded, trim, industry-friendly, tech-savvy creator of 'cyber' Hyderabad, was one of the most powerful politicians in the country and a crucial ally for the Vajpayee-led NDA. The business dailies gushed over him as the CEO of Andhra Pradesh, a man who was driving Hyderabad's IT superpower dream. He had virtually forced the NDA to call an early election in 2004, a move that proved fatal for him. The moment he lost the election, the world suddenly turned against him. When he was in power, we would all queue up to interview him; out of power, he was ignored. Whenever he'd call to say, 'Let's meet,' I, too, found myself making excuses. Political Delhi is a ruthless city and an out-of-office Naidu just didn't make news.

But I did meet him in early 2014 while he was negotiating an alliance with the BJP. 'Modi is a very far-sighted leader,' he told me. 'We need to come together to defeat the Congress which has divided my state.' I asked him whether his claim to be a 'secular' politician would take a knock if he joined a Modi-led NDA. 'At the moment, the challenge before us is to save Andhra Pradesh,' was the response. Modi's past was being quietly buried by his one-time political adversaries.